

First, a brief introduction:

To all the theatre students involved in the production of *The Woodsman* at Timpview High School, and of course, to Mrs. Shanklin-Napierski.

My name is Belle Frahm Menzie, and I am a reviewer and editor for Utah Theatre Bloggers Association. I have been reviewing shows across the state of Utah for the past three years, ranging from high-budget, professional productions to no-budget, local shows. In addition to reviewing shows, I have been a life-long theatre lover, performing since I was about 5 years old all the way through college. I recently graduated from BYU with a degree in Theatre Arts Studies after a 6 week theatre study abroad to London where I saw about 50 productions across the West End. I have been to Broadway multiple times, and have probably seen close to 500 live theatre performances in my lifetime.

Now, why am I telling you this? I want to give you my background so that you all know that the review that I am writing today is not just because your teacher brought some strange college friend to write nice things about you. I want *you* to know that *I* know my stuff. I promised your teacher that I would “review [the show] fairly and positively, providing some constructive feedback... so [that you] wouldn’t feel like it’s just a puff piece!”

With that said, my first thought when I think of your production is consistently and continually, **bravo**. With utmost regards, **bravo**.

I left the high school parking lot after watching your performance dumbfounded by the talent, dedication, and skill of each one of you in that production, on and off stage. I thought to myself, “Of all the professional productions that I review throughout Utah, why can’t they be like this high school one I just watched?” I promised your teacher that I would provide constructive feedback to help hone your magnificent skills going forward, and I will try my best. If after reading the specifics of my review you find yourself wanting for more areas to improve, please know that I am genuinely trying my best to find a place for you to be better. You all just made it that hard.

So, without further ado, here is my honest review of your production of *The Woodsman*.

Timpview's *The Woodsman*

While we all know the famous story of *The Wizard of Oz*, you may not know the backstory to the famous tinman. Edward Hardy and James Ortiz took it upon themselves to tell this story when they adapted the 1918 sequel, "The Tin Woodman of Oz," into a nearly wordless play. The show is beautifully written, relying on actors' movements to be able to tell the story. A challenging piece, this show is rarely licensed out anymore, (mostly because of a lawsuit), but one high school managed to get the rights to perform the show at Timpview High in Provo, Utah. If there were any doubts that a group of high schoolers would do justice to the piece, the doubters would be proven wrong in every sold-out show they might have attended at Timpview.

Timpview's production of *The Woodsman* began with a slow chorus of songbirds being heard onstage as the ensemble wandered on. Even though I was sitting in the front row, it took me several minutes to realize that the cast members were making the pitch perfect song bird noises with their own voices, and not relying on any backtracks for help. The incredible realism to their bird noises set the stage for the quality of the performance from the very first scene.

In the same realm of sound, student violinist Zach Karpowitz accompanied actors for the entire length of the show, expertly navigating variable acting cues, scene changes, and even adding in some humor now and then. Karpowitz was so expert, in fact, that I wondered multiple times if he was a professional violinist hired for this production.

Brooklyn Chennault and Lucy Kocherhans didn't let Karpowitz run away with the production, however, as they both masterfully puppeted the Witch, combining voice and body into their sinister portrayal. The ability of these two young actors to synchronize their movements and intentions whilst puppeteering a large role in the play was astoundingly detailed. Their impressive coordination spoke volumes to the practice they put into rehearsing this challenge, and to the skilled direction of director Mrs. Napierski.

This was a common theme throughout the night, as many exquisite performances were a clear sign of, somewhat ironically, both holistic and detailed-oriented direction, but also of intense dedication and talent. One doesn't need to look much further than lead actor Cannon Hadfield to see the caliber of talent that this production produced. Hadfield could have easily been satisfied with relying on his physical movements and vocal (yet wordless) comedy to carry his emotional performance of the show, as both were poignantly exceptional. However, Hadfield first impresses with a resolute opening monologue, confidently leading the company of young actors with a pace of professionalism far beyond his years.

The opening monologue is one of the best examples of why this production was such a success. The entire company, from main actor to the one all the way in the back, understood the script in its entirety. There was a sense of connection and coordination between each actor that echoed to the audience, making us believe anything they depicted onstage. This was also seen repeatedly with the staggered entrances and exits of the ensemble upstage throughout the show. Not only were they providing background noise vocally, (of which the crows still amaze me as to

how they effortlessly produced such life-like noises), but they were seamlessly preparing for the next scene, whilst also supporting their fellow performers onstage.

This sense of camaraderie and talent was also seen in the other leads of the play, specifically the characters of Nimmee, Mother and Father. Abbie Drake as Nimmee brought a child-like wonder to the sheltered character, exploring her space with newness and vibrancy in each step. This was the same for Gracie Griffin as Mother and Sam Wilson as Father. While not together onstage for a long time, the pair created a beautiful love story, masterfully aging with their characters.

There were only a couple of moments that I felt slightly lost in the story, unsure of exactly where the scene was headed, but this was more of a reflection on the script than the production. While there were perhaps some moments of confusion for the audience, they were few and fleeting, and the actors' confidence in themselves and their script provided a sense of security that cleared up any lasting questions.

When thinking about the rest of the ensemble, I am again repeatedly impressed by their dedication to building a world together. A highlight of the cast was the group of Tinkers who came out towards the end of the play: JaneEsther Deans, Daisy Eliason, Mitchell Harding, and Vienna Van Dyke. While their performances were purposefully lively and therefore unsettling, their characters were brought to life in large part due to Nate Hendrickson's sound design. In addition to the actors' tap dancing, they used mechanical props (designed by Genna Cluff) that created the sound of working with metal. Their naturally mechanical tendencies were turned to music by the Hendrickson's and Cluff's brilliant design of onstage foley.

Another impressive technical element was the set design, led by Seth Prince. The set immediately transported the audience into the world of the play, carefully crafted to be a woodland scene, fit with movable set pieces and rustic set blocks. The world-building set design was well accompanied by the costume and hairstyling designs, by Eva Marrè and Emma Wheelwright, respectively. Their design choices subtly told the story of the Tin Man that is well known from Oz, including Nick Chopper's hair looking particularly "munchkin"-esque, and a foreshadowed Dorothy appearance with actress Rilo Webb's costume. Outside of Oz, Nimmie's costume featured a patchwork dress that easily communicated her lifestyle of scraps and longing. Overall, these three design elements triangulated exactly where we were within the story of Oz.

Another part of the set was a large group of lights hanging in jars from the center of the ceiling, displaying a beautiful array of bulbs. These lights would occasionally flash a bright green, initially introduced as the glow of the distant Emerald City. Throughout the show, those emerald lights would reappear, sometimes quite suddenly. While sometimes slightly confusing as to their purpose, they provided an interesting vertical element for the audience, and an even more distinct way to draw emphasis on a special moment.

As I have reflected on this show and all the beauty and splendor that everyone brought to it, I have found two aspects that worked so seamlessly in the production that they flew under the radar of my notes. Only upon further reflection have I realized my oversight, and how truly vital both the puppetry and dramaturgy has been to create such a wonderful piece of theatre.

Hannah White's puppet designs were on a level I have only seen on a few professional stages. The craft and care that went into creating all the many puppets, and their many versions, resulted in final products that fooled me into believing they were real. White's designs solidified this production as one of the most well-crafted shows I have ever seen.

Similarly, the dramaturgical team led by Lydia Argyle displayed material in the lobby and program, and also undoubtedly behind the scenes, at a collegiate level. The coordination and understanding of the script is a direct result of dramaturgical efforts from each member of the production. Because of this dramaturgy, it breathlessly became infused into the audience's experience. These seemingly invisible design elements elevated this production beyond my imagination before, during, and after the show. (Truly, I still don't know how it was this good.)

If you were able to see Timpview's production of *The Woodsman*, count yourself lucky. You may have just seen the best piece of theatre around these parts for a long, long time.

End of Review

All my best for whatever your future holds.

And again, **bravo**.

Belle Frahm Menzie